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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

English

Reading Comprehension

Official Syllabus · Language Test · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA official CUET(UG) 2026 syllabus — English (101), the current 2027 baseline)	Skills the questions test
The passage frame	Three types of passages (maximum 300 words):	Reading a short unseen passage once and holding its main idea.
Type 1 — Factual	Factual	Locating facts, figures, dates and causes, and spotting swapped details.
Type 2 — Narrative	Narrative	Tracking who did what, in what order, and why.
Type 3 — Literary	Literary	Sensing tone, mood and suggested meaning behind the words.

EXAM PATTERN

CUET UG pattern (NTA official information bulletin and syllabus, 2026 cycle — the current 2027 baseline): each test paper carries **50 compulsory questions** in **60 minutes**, with +5 for every correct answer and −1 for every incorrect answer. The English paper tests comprehension of unseen passages of up to 300 words — the answer to every question is sitting inside the passage, so accurate reading beats fast guessing.

What Reading Comprehension Actually Tests

Here is the best news in the whole English paper: a comprehension passage is an **open-book test**. The passage is in front of you, and every answer is inside it. Nobody is testing your memory or your general knowledge. The skill being tested is **finding and understanding** — can you read a short text once, know what each paragraph is doing, and then put your finger on the exact line that answers a question?

- **It is not a vocabulary test.** Hard words in the passage are almost always explained by the words around them.
- **It is not a knowledge test.** A passage about beekeeping does not need a beekeeper. Everything needed is written down.
- **It is a finding test.** Students lose marks by answering from memory instead of returning to the lines.
- **It is a judging test.** Three options will look tempting; only one is fully supported by the passage.

- **300 words is short.** One calm, careful read is enough — rushing a second read costs more time than it saves.

REAL-WORLD ANALOGY

Reading comprehension is like being handed a **map before a treasure hunt**. The map (the passage) already shows where everything is. You do not win by guessing where treasure might be — you win by **reading the map** and walking to the marked spot. The options in an MCQ are like four villagers all claiming to know the spot: only the one the map actually supports is right.

The Three Passage Types

The syllabus names three passage types. Each one feels different, and each rewards a slightly different reading style. Think of them as three guests at dinner: the **factual** guest talks like a newsreader, the **narrative** guest tells you a story, and the **literary** guest describes a sunset in a way that makes you feel something.

Type	What it sounds like	What questions lean on
Factual	News report or textbook page: facts, numbers, dates, findings — science, history, economy, environment	Locate-and-match: figures, causes, "which of the following is true"
Narrative	A story in order: someone does something, something happens, it ends a certain way	Sequence and motive: what happened first, why the person acted, what changed
Literary	Poem extract or descriptive prose: feelings, images, mood — words suggest more than they say	Tone, mood and meaning: how the writer feels, what an image suggests, the best title

- **Reading a factual passage:** read once for the **main point of each paragraph**, and underline numbers and dates as you pass them. Options often swap these — 90 cm becomes 190 cm, 1947 becomes 1974.
- **Reading a narrative passage:** keep a tiny timeline in your head — **who, then what, then why**. Questions love asking what happened first or why a character acted.
- **Reading a literary passage:** after each line ask, "Is the writer happy, sad, curious, critical?" Mood words are the clues. "Sadly", "luckily", "gently" are signposts pointing at the tone.
- **The shared rule:** whichever type appears, the answer must come from **the passage's own words**, not from your head.

The Four-Step Reading Method

One method works on all three types. Learn it here, use it in every practice passage, and it becomes automatic by exam day. The steps matter because they stop the two classic mistakes: **reading blindly** (no idea what the questions want) and **hunting first** (jumping to questions before understanding the passage, so every line looks equally important).

- **Step 1 — Read the passage once.** Normal speed. Get the main idea of every paragraph. Do not memorise; do not underline everything.
- **Step 2 — Read the questions.** For each, note what it wants: a fact, a reason, a feeling, or a word's meaning.
- **Step 3 — Return and locate.** Go back to the passage and find the **exact lines** that answer each question. Put a finger on the line before looking at the options.
- **Step 4 — Eliminate, then pick.** Strike out options the passage never says. Choose from what is left — usually two options fall at once.

THE METHOD IN ACTION — 40 SECONDS

Suppose a question asks: **"Why did the farmer cover the seedlings at night?"**

- **Weak habit:** remember "the passage said something about cold" and tick an option about cold **without returning**.
- **Strong habit:** step 3 — go back, find the line: "He covered them with straw so the frost would not touch the young leaves."
- **Result:** the finger is on the evidence, the correct option is found in seconds, and even a tricky option about "keeping the soil moist" loses because the line says **frost**.

The Question Families — and the One-Line Method for Each

Almost every comprehension question belongs to one of six families. Learn the family, and you already know the method before you finish reading the question.

Question family	What the stem sounds like	The one-line method
Main idea	"The main purpose of the passage is…", "What is the passage mainly about?"	Ask: does this cover the WHOLE passage, start to finish? One paragraph is not the main idea
Detail	"According to the passage…", "How much / when / who…"	Locate the exact line — never answer from memory
Vocabulary in context	"In this passage, X most nearly means…"	Replace the word with each option; keep the one that leaves the sentence's meaning unchanged

Question family	What the stem sounds like	The one-line method
Inference	"It can be inferred that…", "The passage suggests…"	Take one small step beyond the lines — if you need a leap, it is too far
Tone / attitude	"The tone of the writer is…", "The writer seems…"	Collect the mood words (sadly, gladly, unfortunately) and match their feeling
Best title	"The most suitable title is…"	Halfway between main idea and title style: not too narrow, not too wide, no drama

- **The inference boundary is the most tested line in this topic.** "The road was wet all morning" **suggests** it rained at night. It does **not** prove a cloud burst flooded the town — that is a leap, not an inference.
- **Titles obey the Goldilocks rule:** "Bees" is too wide, "The Waggle Dance Angle Experiment" is too narrow, "How Honeybees Share Food Directions" is just right.

Worked Example 1 — A Factual Passage

READ THE PASSAGE (ABOUT 90 WORDS)

Honeybees communicate the location of food through a movement pattern called the waggle dance. When a scout bee finds nectar, it returns to the hive and dances in a figure-of-eight shape. The angle of the dance shows the direction of the food relative to the sun, while the length of the straight run tells the distance — a longer run means food that is farther away. Other bees follow the dancer, touch it with their antennae, and then fly out to search. For food very close to the hive, scouts switch to a simpler round dance.

Q1. In the waggle dance, the DISTANCE of the food is shown by:

(A) the angle of the dance
(B) the length of the straight run
(C) the number of bees following
(D) the size of the hive

Q2. A scout bee switches to the round dance when the food is:

(A) very close to the hive
(B) far from the hive
(C) hidden underground
(D) already finished

- **Q1, the strong path:** step 3 — return to the line "the length of the straight run tells the distance". The angle shows **direction**, so option A is the classic swap trap. Answer: (B).
- **Q2, the strong path:** the last line says "for food very close to the hive, scouts switch to a simpler round dance". Options C and D were never mentioned — out of scope. Answer: (A).

Worked Example 2 — A Narrative Passage

READ THE PASSAGE (ABOUT 95 WORDS)

When Meera's school announced a science fair, she signed up at once — and then panicked. Her model of a water purifier leaked on the first trial, and the sand layer floated instead of sinking. Her elder brother laughed, but her grandmother quietly asked, "What does the water actually need to pass through?" Meera tried again, this time pressing the sand down firmly and adding a layer of pebbles below it. On the third trial the water came out clear. On the day of the fair she answered the judges' questions by pointing to the layers in her bottle. She did not win the first prize, but walking home she felt she had won something better.

Q3. Why did Meera's first trial fail?

(A) The water was too dirty to purify
(B) The layers inside were not arranged properly
(C) The judges disliked her model
(D) Her brother broke the purifier

Q4. The last line suggests that Meera valued:

(A) the first prize she missed
(B) her brother's laughter
(C) what the struggle taught her
(D) her grandmother's sympathy

- **Q3, the strong path:** the passage lists the failure — it "leaked" and "the sand layer floated" — and the fix was pressing the sand down and adding pebbles. That is **arrangement of layers**, exactly option B. Answer: (B).
- **Q4, the strong path:** "won something better" right after NOT winning the prize — one small inference: the learning mattered more than the trophy. Answer: (C).

Worked Example 3 — A Literary Passage

READ THE PASSAGE (ABOUT 90 WORDS)

The old banyan stood at the edge of the village like a patient teacher. Its branches, heavy with leaves, bent low as if bowing to every child who climbed them. In summer it held a roof of shade over the market; in the rains it caught the first drops on its wide leaves and let them fall, gently, on the sleepers below. Travellers rested in its hollows; birds argued happily in its crown. When the storms came and younger trees fell, the banyan only swayed, its aerial roots gripping the earth like a hundred hands.

Q5. The banyan is compared to a "patient teacher" because it:

(A) grows taller every year
(B) shelters and guides everyone patiently
(C) stands far from the village
(D) drops its leaves in summer

Q6. The tone of the passage can best be described as:

(A) angry and bitter
(B) cold and scientific
(C) affectionate and admiring
(D) frightened and tense

- **Q5, the strong path:** an image comparison — teacher, bowing branches, roof of shade, gripping hands. The shared idea is **shelter and patient care**, option B. Options A, C, D are either false or missing from the lines. Answer: (B).
- **Q6, the strong path:** mood words — "patient", "bowing", "gently", "argued happily". The feeling is warm admiration, option C. Nothing in the text is angry, scientific or tense. Answer: (C).

The Vocabulary-in-Context Shortcut

You will meet a hard word and be asked what it means **in this passage**. The trap is answering from your dictionary memory — words change meaning with their neighbours. "Run" means a jog on a track, a cricket score, or a tear in stockings, depending on the sentence. So never define; **replace**.

- **Step 1 — Cover the word** with your finger and read the sentence around it.
- **Step 2 — Predict your own word.** Say aloud what should fit there: "The coach's blunt remarks stung, but they improved focus" — something like **harsh** or **direct**.
- **Step 3 — Match the options to your prediction.** Pick the option closest to the word you said, not the fanciest option on the list.
- **Step 4 — Re-read the sentence with your chosen option inside it.** If the meaning stays intact, you have your answer.

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REAL-WORLD ANALOGY

A word in a sentence is like a **spice in a dish**. The same chilli changes meaning in a sweet curry versus a fried snack — the dish around it decides what it contributes. Test every option the same way: drop it into the dish and see if the flavour (the meaning) survives.

Key Rules and Strategies: One-Stop Revision

READING COMPREHENSION — EVERY RULE ON ONE PAGE

Rule	Statement	Exam use
Open-book rule	Every answer sits inside the passage — your general knowledge is not evidence	Kills out-of-scope options
Four-step method	Read once, read questions, return and locate, eliminate then pick	The default plan for every passage

Rule	Statement	Exam use
Factual reading	Main idea per paragraph; underline numbers and dates	Catches swapped-figure traps
Narrative reading	Track who, then what, then why	Sequence and motive questions
Literary reading	Collect mood words; ask how the writer feels	Tone and inference questions
Main idea	Must cover the whole passage, not one paragraph	Main-idea and purpose questions
Detail questions	Finger on the exact line before looking at options	Detail and "according to" questions
Vocabulary in context	Replace the word; keep the sentence's meaning	Word-meaning questions
Inference boundary	One small step beyond the lines — no leaps	Suggests / infers questions
Extreme words	Always, never, only, all — treat with suspicion	Elimination shortcut
Title rule	Not too narrow, not too wide, no drama	Best-title questions
Marking maths	+5 correct, −1 wrong: answer from evidence, skip only when truly clueless	Attempt strategy

Common Errors and Special Cases

THE TRAPS THIS TOPIC SETS — READ BEFORE THE MOCK

The habit you assume	The twist	The trap in the question
"I remember the answer"	Memory is not evidence — the exact line is	Answering from first impression
"The option sounds true"	True in real life, absent from the passage = out of scope	Fact-checking with outside knowledge
"First option reads well — done"	Three wrong options are built to read well too	Not reading all four options

The habit you assume	The twist	The trap in the question
"One strong paragraph = main idea"	The main idea spans every paragraph	Too-narrow main-idea options
"Hard word = fancy meaning"	Context decides meaning, not grandness	Vocabulary-in-context options
"A suggested detail = proven fact"	Inference is one small step, not a leap	Over-inferred options
"Tone = the topic of the passage"	Tone is the writer's FEELING about the topic	Tone questions on serious topics
"Titles should be catchy"	Exam titles are precise, not dramatic	Clickbait-style title options

The 60-Second Self-Test

Cover the answers, say each one aloud, then check. If any answer takes longer than ten seconds, revisit that section.

- **What are the three passage types?** → Factual, narrative, literary — maximum 300 words.
- **Name the four steps of the reading method in order.** → Read once, read questions, return and locate, eliminate then pick.
- **What is the one-line rule for "most nearly means" questions?** → Replace the word; keep the sentence's meaning.
- **How far can an inference go?** → One small step beyond the lines — never a leap.
- **What do you do with an option that is true in real life but missing from the passage?** → Eliminate it — out of scope.
- **Two marks sit in front of you: a hunch and a located line. Which wins?** → The located line, every time.

Timing on Exam Day

A 300-word passage is roughly a one-minute read at a calm speed — so the clock is your friend, not your enemy, as long as each step gets a fixed budget. The table below shows a simple split for one passage with its set of questions. Adjust the minutes to your own speed while practising, but keep the **order** of the steps fixed.

Step	Budget	What happens in this step
Read the passage once	2 minutes	Calm full read; note each paragraph's main idea; mark numbers and mood words

Step	Budget	What happens in this step
Read the questions	1 minute	Tag each question: fact, reason, feeling or word meaning
Return and locate	1 minute per question	Finger on the exact line; only then glance at options
Eliminate and answer	30 seconds per question	Strike the unsupported options; pick and move on without re-litigating

- **Never re-read the whole passage** to hunt one answer — jump to the paragraph that owns that question's idea.
- **Never park a question for "later thinking"** inside the same passage; answer it from the line or mark and move — the −1 penalty punishes stubborn guesses.
- **One passage at a time:** finish its full set before starting the next passage, so the context stays warm in your head.
- **Practise with a timer at home.** The method only becomes automatic when the clock runs in practice, not just on exam day.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture

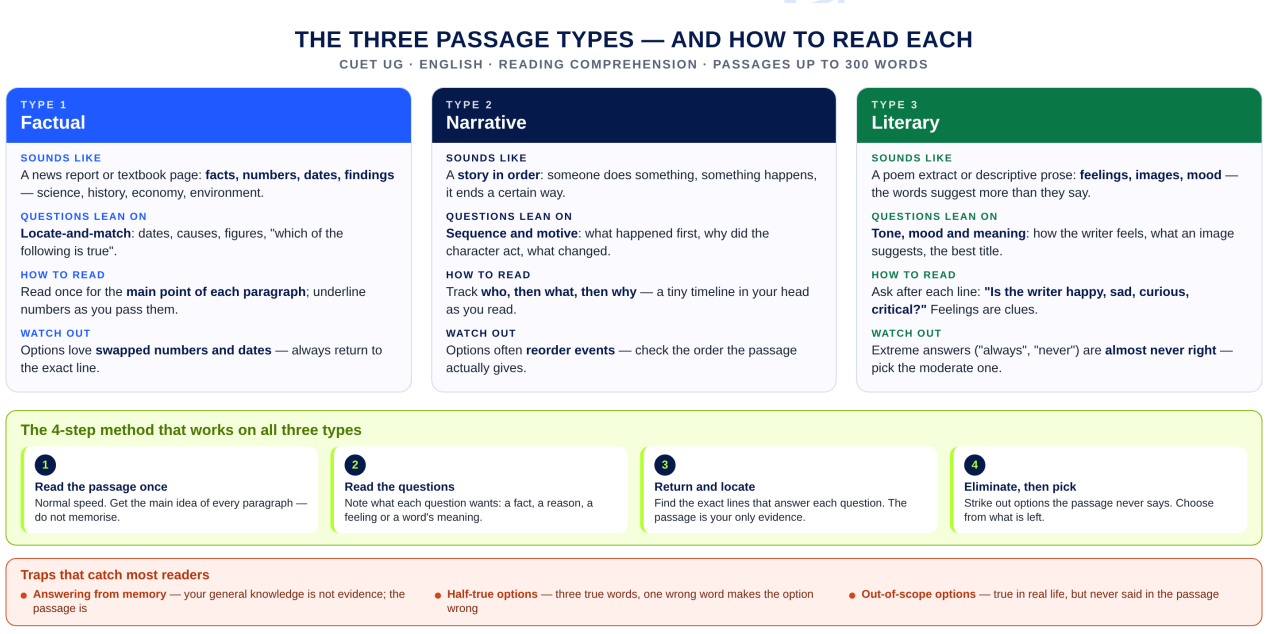


Figure 1: The three passage types side by side — what each sounds like, what its questions lean on, how to read it — with the four-step method and the classic traps below.



Figure 2: Chapter mindmap: the passage types, the reading method, the six question families, the elimination skill and the scoring habits that tie them together.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions in the CUET UG style — a mix of strategy and passage-based items, exactly like the families you just revised. Each correct answer earns +5; each incorrect one costs −1, so answer from evidence, not from hope.

Q7. In the four-step reading method, what do you do IMMEDIATELY after reading the questions?

(A) Read the passage a second time from the start
(B) Return to the passage and locate the exact answer lines
(C) Choose the option that sounds most sensible
(D) Guess and move on to save time

Q8. Bamboo can grow up to 90 cm in a single day, making it one of the fastest-growing plants on Earth. Some bamboo species flower only once in 40 to 60 years — and then die. According to the passage, some bamboo species are unusual because they:

(A) grow fastest in winter
(B) flower once in decades and then die
(C) never grow taller than a shrub
(D) need no rainfall at all

Q9. The coach's blunt remarks stung, but they improved the team's focus. In this sentence, "blunt" most nearly means:

(A) broken
(B) direct and frank
(C) polite
(D) silent

Q10. Ravi saved his pocket money for six months — not for the cricket bat in the shop window, but for his sister's birthday. Why did Ravi save his pocket money?

(A) To buy the cricket bat
(B) To buy a birthday gift for his sister
(C) To lend money to a friend
(D) To donate it at school

Q11. Every city watches its water disappear each summer. Rainwater harvesting — catching rain on rooftops and guiding it into storage pits — offers a simple fix: the same roofs that leak heat can collect thousands of litres in a season. The main idea of the passage is that:

(A) rooftops leak heat in summer
(B) rainwater harvesting can ease urban water shortage
(C) storage pits are expensive to build
(D) cities receive too much rainfall

Q12. The lamps in the old house flickered as if they too were afraid of the night. The line suggests:

(A) the house had faulty electric wiring
(B) an atmosphere of fear and unease
(C) the lamps were newly bought
(D) a power cut had begun

Q13. Sadly, the wetland that once hosted thousands of migratory birds is now a multi-storey parking lot. The tone of the writer is:

(A) joyful
(B) regretful
(C) neutral and bored
(D) confused

Q14. Sleep is not rest for the brain alone. During deep sleep, the brain replays the day's experiences and moves important ones into long-term storage. Students who sleep well after studying remember more than those who stay up revising. The MOST suitable title for the passage is:

(A) Sleep Helps the Brain Remember
(B) The History of Sleep Research
(C) Why Staying Awake Is Fun
(D) Dreams and Their Meanings

Q15. An option states a fact that is completely true in the real world, but the passage never mentions it. This option is:

(A) correct — true options are always right
(B) out of scope and should be eliminated
(C) the answer if it sounds impressive
(D) a bonus fact worth marking

Q16. Tea was first drunk in China as a medicine, long before it became a daily pleasure. It reached Europe only in the seventeenth century, carried by Dutch traders. According to the passage, tea reached Europe in the:

(A) sixteenth century, by Portuguese sailors
(B) seventeenth century, carried by Dutch traders
(C) eighteenth century, through land routes
(D) seventeenth century, as a medicine for kings

Detailed Solutions

Each solution shows the working, not just the verdict — cover the answer line, attempt the reasoning, then compare.

Sol. Q7. The method's order is fixed: passage once, then questions, then **return and locate**. Re-reading everything wastes time, and choosing by ear ignores the evidence rule.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The second line states it word for word: some species "flower only once in 40 to 60 years — and then die". Options A, C and D bring in facts the passage never claims.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. Replace test: "The coach's **direct** remarks stung, but they improved focus" — meaning intact. "Broken" plays on the other sense of blunt; "polite" and "silent" contradict the stinging effect.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. The dash makes it explicit: "not for the cricket bat… but for his sister's birthday". The passage even blocks the trap option A in advance.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q11. The passage opens with the water problem and offers harvesting as "a simple fix" — that pairing IS the main idea. Option A is one supporting detail, not the passage's purpose.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q12. "As if they too were afraid" is the clue — the lamps are personified to build a feeling of fear. Take it as imagery, not an electrician's report.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q13. "Sadly" is a mood word doing the writer's feeling in one word — regret over a lost wetland. Joyful and bored contradict it; neutral ignores the signal word.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q14. The title must cover the whole passage: replaying experiences, storage, students remembering. Option A does exactly that; the others are off-topic or too narrow.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q15. This is the definition of out of scope — the open-book rule says only the passage counts. True or false **outside** the passage is irrelevant.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q16. Two facts to lock together: the century (seventeenth) and the carrier (Dutch traders). Option D is the century trap — tea reached Europe as a pleasure, though it began as medicine in China.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

Dropped marks above? Find your slip here and rewrite the corrected rule in your own words.

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q7 option A	Re-reading everything after the questions	After questions, go straight to the exact lines — step 3
Q9 option A	Taking the dictionary's other meaning of blunt	Context picks the meaning — here it is about speech, not edges
Q11 option A	Lifting one detail as the main idea	The main idea must span the whole passage, not one clause
Q12 option A	Reading a literary image literally	Personified lamps build mood — treat images as feelings
Q13 option C	Missing the signal word "Sadly"	Mood words announce tone — collect them before answering
Q16 option D	Keeping the century but swapping the purpose	Pair facts carefully: medicine was China; Europe got a drink via traders

Your 5-Day Passage Practice Plan

Skills grow with spaced practice, not one marathon sitting. Here is a five-day plan that trains one passage type at a time and then mixes them — exactly how the exam will serve them. Each day needs only 25 to 30 minutes.

Day	Practice task	What to check while practising
Day 1	Two factual passages	Did you underline numbers and dates? Did every answer come from a located line?
Day 2	Two narrative passages	Could you retell the who → what → why chain in two sentences after reading?
Day 3	Two literary passages	Did you name the writer's mood before opening the options?
Day 4	One passage of each type	Did the four-step order hold under time? Where did you slip — reading, locating or eliminating?
Day 5	Mixed set, timed	Did the minute-per-question budget hold? Any question answered from memory instead of a line?

- **Keep an error diary:** one line per mistake — the question family, the trap that caught you, and the corrected rule in your words.
- **Re-read your diary** before the exam hall, not the passages — your own slips are the highest-value revision you own.

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